

AUGUST

August is the time for Hanabi Firework displays. The Japanese have mastered the art of firework production and the colors and styles of the mid-air art are utterly unique. As the ball explodes high in the sky and expands in a beautiful circle of glittering stars, each star transforms to colored light and shimmers slowly into the river or sea. Imagine this multiplied by a thousand and you have a good idea of Japan's world famous firework displays.

SEPTEMBER

The temperature starts to cool in September. Sea Paradise in Hakkeijima (one hour from central Tokyo) features the first jet coaster in Japan to swing out over the ocean and one of Japan's largest and most beautiful aquariums filled with more than 100,000 sea creatures. Another destination unique to Japan is Tokyo DisneySea Park. This is the only Disney facility in the world that features live performances, attractions and activities based on the legends and myths of the sea.

OCTOBER

The sky becomes crystal blue and leaves begin to hint of Autumn in October. Leisurely strolls in the traditional grounds of a Japanese temple would be a lovely event for an October visit. Sensoji (Asakusa Kannon Temple) is Tokyo's oldest temple (completed in 645). The entrance to the Temple is Kaminari Mon or Thunder gate, which is followed by a 200 meter-long shopping area called Nakamise which features traditional Japanese gifts and snacks.

NOVEMBER

The best way to enjoy the lovely colors of November, is a leisurely hike. Some 75% of Japan is made up of mountains and there are multiple hiking options just outside the city. Mount Takao is about 50 minutes from Tokyo with a peak of 599 meters. On clear days, Mount Fuji stands majestic in the distance. There is also a traditional shrine on the way down and a cable car to speed the way home.

DECEMBER

Like much of the rest of the world, Japan is winding down in December. Going to a traditional Japanese pub or "Izakaya" at this time of year is a great experience. Japanese companies hold "Bounenkai" literally a party to "Forget the past year and look forward to the New Year". After the Bounenkai party, most participants will move on to Karaoke singing parties at huge "Karaoke box" buildings. A Bounenkai experience will reveal the wild and fun side of Japanese people.

(As told to Veeshal Bakshi)

